

Travel Diary

Philippines & Thailand 2026



*Route: Cebu (Oslob, Sumilon, Moalboal) → Koh Tao → Koh Samui
Sun August 30 – Sun September 13, 2026*

Contents

Day 1 – Sunday/Monday, August 30/31 – Via Hong Kong to Cebu

Day 2 – Tuesday, September 1 – Sumilon Island

Day 3 – Wednesday, September 2 – Whale Sharks in Oslob & On to Moalboal

Day 4 – Thursday/Friday, September 3/4 – Moalboal & Cebu City

Day 5 – Saturday/Sunday, September 5/6 – To Thailand: Koh Tao

Day 6 – Monday–Wednesday, September 7–9 – Koh Tao: Snorkelling & Island Tour

Day 7 – Thursday/Friday, September 10/11 – Diving the Wreck & Sairee by Night

Day 8 – Saturday/Sunday, September 12/13 – Koh Samui & the Journey Home

Day 1 – Sunday/Monday, August 30/31 – Via Hong Kong to Cebu

Getting there: Overnight from Frankfurt to Hong Kong, half a day changing planes in the vast terminal at Chek Lap Kok, then on to Cebu. "Dayon kamo sa Cebu!" – welcome in Cebuano, the language of the Visayas.











Down the south coast: With a driver across the bridges to Cebu City, then some three hours down the south coast to Oslob. On the way: tricycles, motorbikes with sidecars that serve as taxis in the Philippines. In the evening cocktails, coconut and barbecue skewers at a roadside grill.













Day 2 – Tuesday, September 1 – Sumilon Island

Sumilon Island: By tricycle to the jetty, then a few minutes across by boat. The reef off Sumilon was declared the Philippines' first marine sanctuary in 1974. The island is small and wooded, with a sandbar that shifts with the tides. A cave bears the name of the Japanese general Yamashita – legend has it that part of the gold he hid during the Second World War lies here.



















Day 3 – Wednesday, September 2 – Whale Sharks in Oslob & On to Moalboal

Whale sharks in Tan-awan: Early in the morning, before the buses arrive, in the haze on the coast at Tan-awan. A few metres from shore, whale sharks – the world's largest fish, over twelve metres long, a harmless plankton feeder. With mask and snorkel they are within arm's reach. The fact that fishermen feed the animals so they stay here is controversial: marine biologists say it alters their migration.

















On to Moalboal: Up the coast via Samboan to the west side of the island and Moalboal. Right off the shore at Panagsama the reef drops away steeply – home to a huge sardine run, millions of fish you can snorkel to straight from the beach. In the evening, sunset over the Tañon Strait, with Negros on the other side.













Day 4 – Thursday/Friday, September 3/4 – Moalboal & Cebu City

White Beach: North of Moalboal lies Basdaku White Beach, a long pale-sand beach. In the afternoon kinilaw – Philippine ceviche – and in the evening sunset on the beach and a German beer garden with wheat beer in Moalboal. Then on to the bars along Panagsama Road.















Cebu City: Back to Cebu City, the oldest city in the Philippines: Magellan landed here in 1521, and in 1565 the Spanish founded their first settlement. In the evening around the Fuente Osmeña roundabout – jeepneys, mopeds, churches, food stalls.

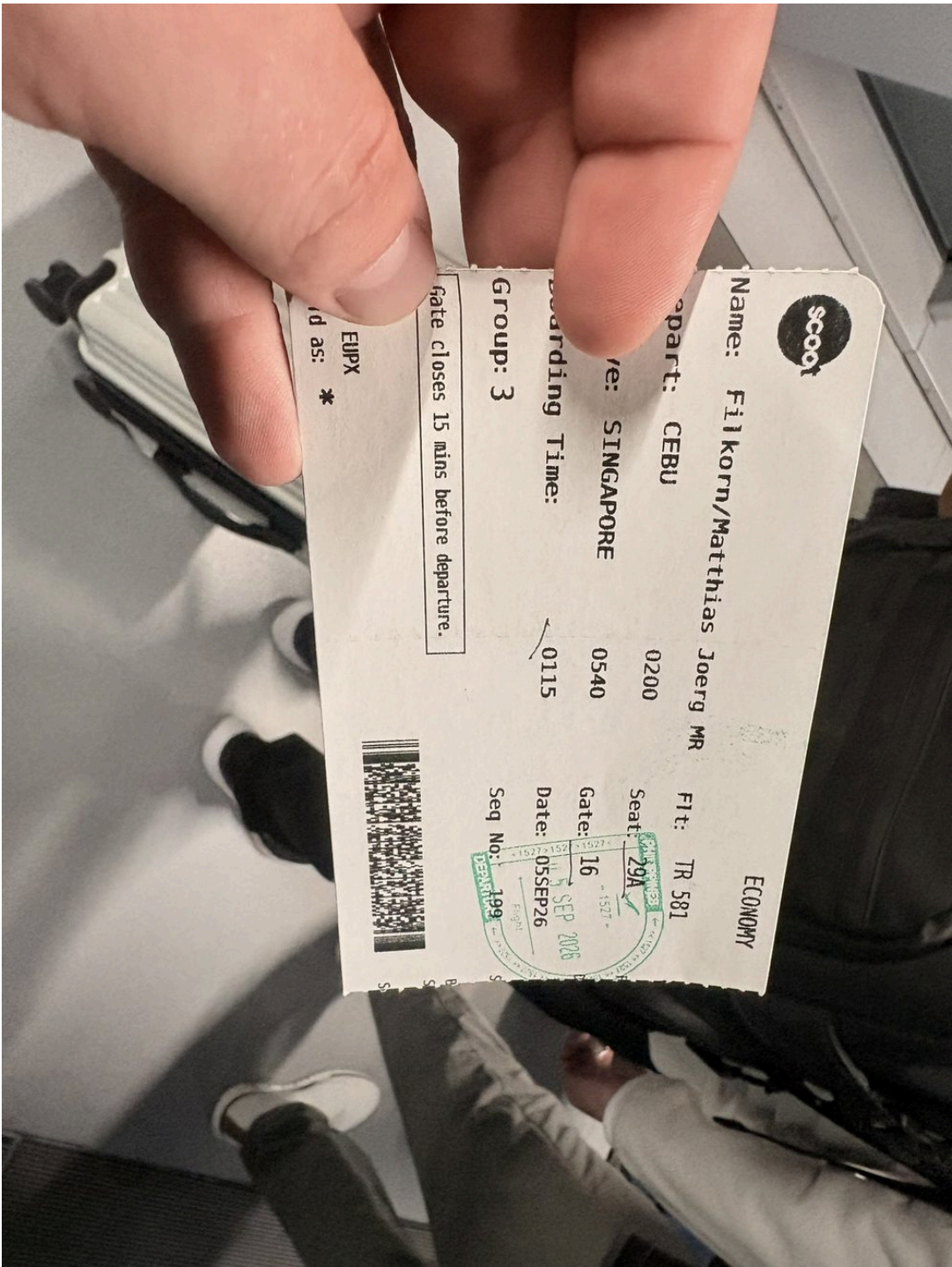






Day 5 – Saturday/Sunday, September 5/6 – To Thailand: Koh Tao

On to Thailand: Night flight from Cebu via Singapore to Koh Samui. The airport there belongs to Bangkok Airways and consists of open, thatched pavilions. By ferry on to Koh Tao – in the evening a Luang Prabang beer on the terrace, the view across the jungle to the sea.









Koh Tao: The "Turtle Island" in the Gulf of Thailand covers only about 21 km² and is one of the places where most people in the world earn their diving certificate. First day: pad thai on Sairee Beach, the bay looking out to Koh Nang Yuan, bars among rocks and driftwood, sunset from the terrace and, in the evening, mu kratha, a tabletop grill with a soup moat.























Day 6 – Monday–Wednesday, September 7–9 – Koh Tao: Snorkelling & Island Tour

Quiet days: Snorkelling in the bay – a small blacktip reef shark glides past just below the surface. Then som tam, spicy papaya salad, in an open wooden pavilion looking out to sea, and every evening the sunset from the terrace.

















Boat tour around the island: By boat around Koh Tao with snorkelling stops. Past Koh Nang Yuan, three small islands joined by a sandbar at low tide. On the way back, a rainbow over the jungle.









Day 7 – Thursday/Friday, September 10/11 – Diving the Wreck & Sairee by Night

Diving the HTMS Sattakut: By dive boat out to the HTMS Sattakut, a former US Navy landing craft from the Second World War that later served in the Thai navy and was sunk off Koh Tao in 2011 as an artificial reef. Today the hull at around 30 m is covered in coral, the gun on the bow is still visible, and huge schools of fish swirl around it.









Sairee by night: In the evening on Sairee Beach: fairy lights and lanterns in the trees, tables right on the sand, bars in white grottoes.













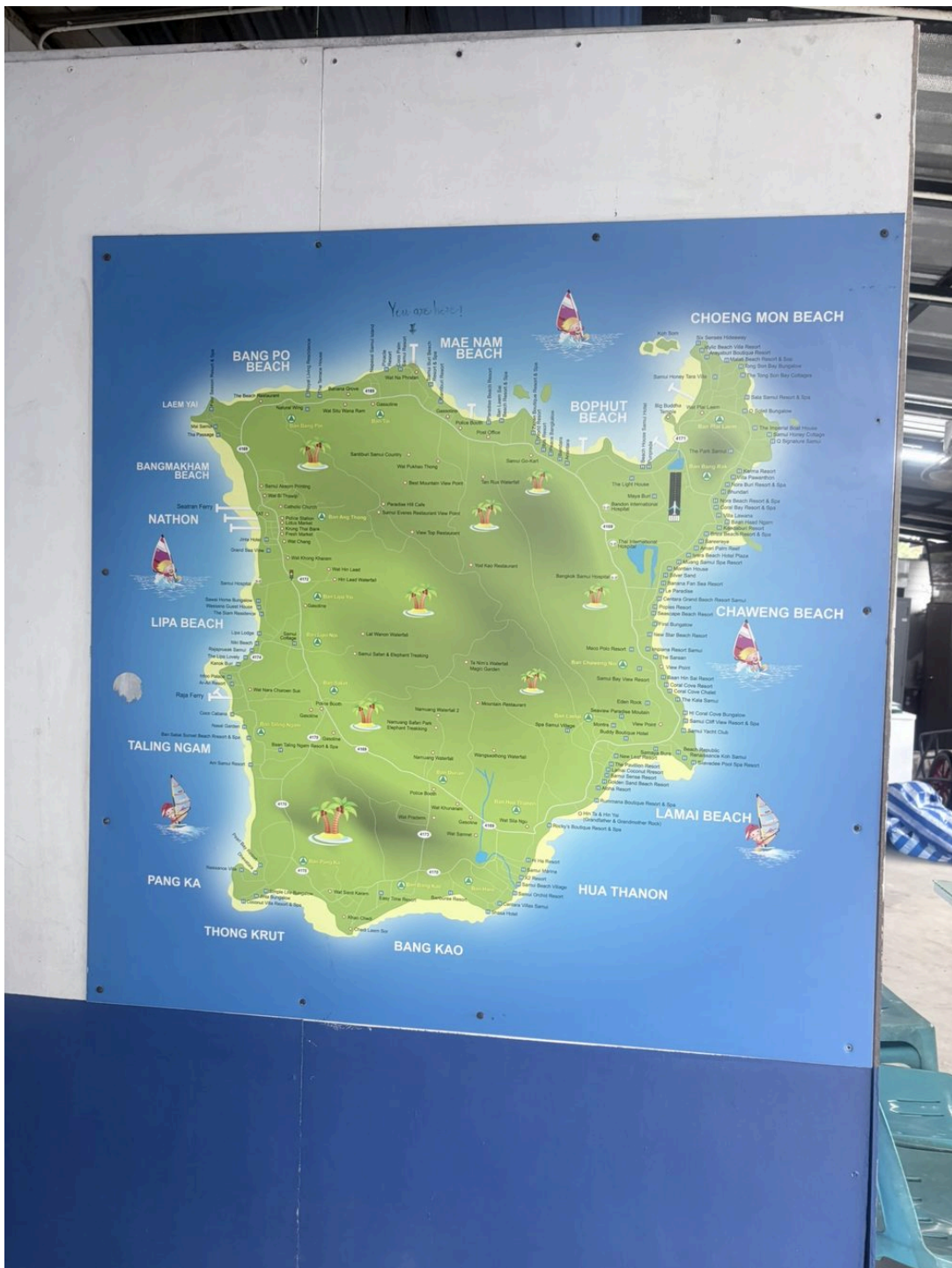




Day 8 – Saturday/Sunday, September 12/13 – Koh Samui & the Journey Home

Koh Samui: By ferry in the rain back to Koh Samui, Thailand's second-largest island. Last evening in Chaweng: Aperol by the roadside, Thai salad with orchids, posters for Muay Thai fights, crowded streets, a fire show on the beach.







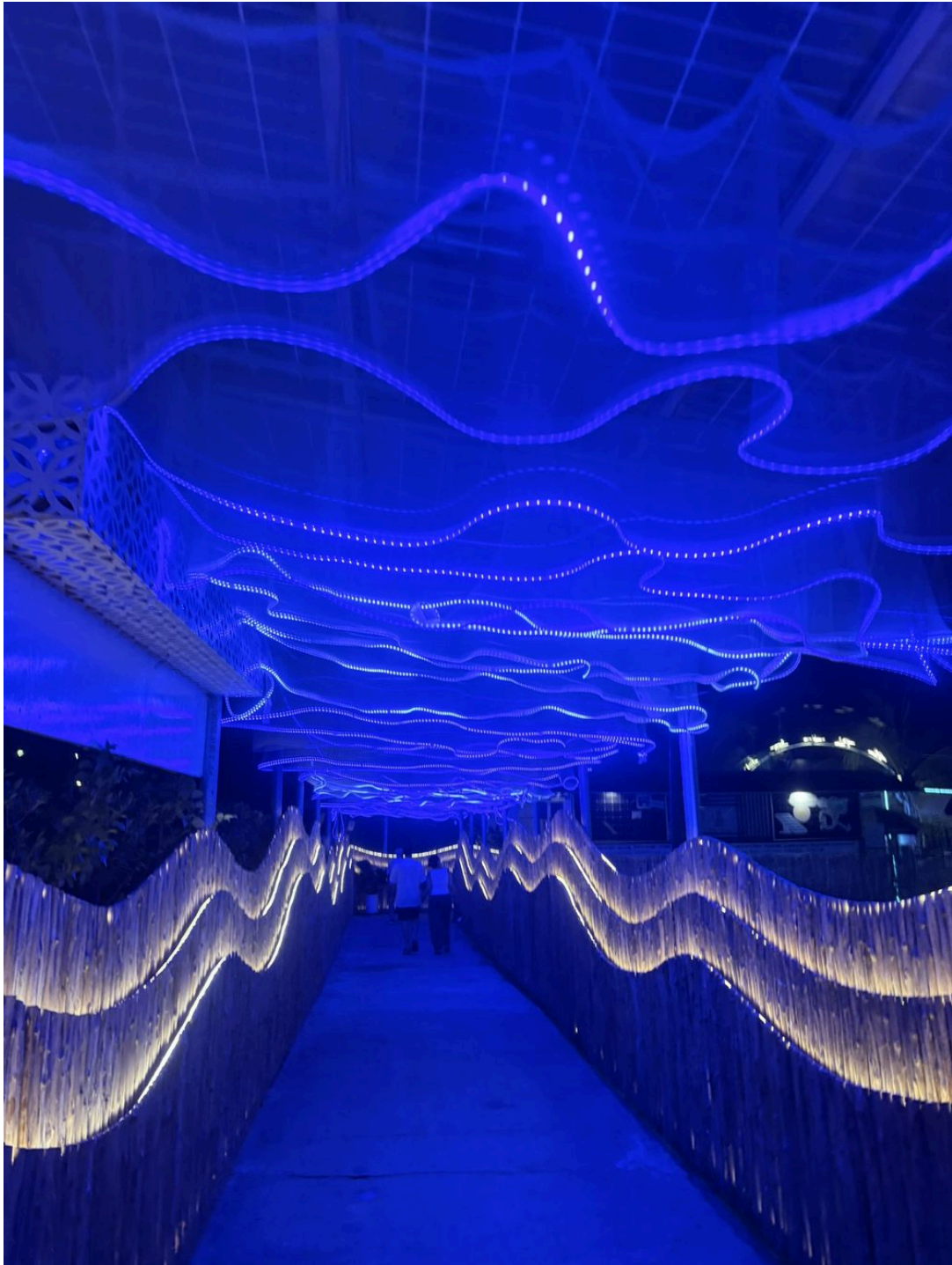












Journey home: On Sunday from Samui's open-air airport via Bangkok back to Frankfurt. Two weeks, two countries, whale sharks and a wreck – and a last look at the mountains below the wing.





